10-MINUTE READ · 1 TEMPLATE

The one-page *app brief.*

Describe the software you need so you get a fixed price, not a guess. Fill-in template, worked example and the 12 questions to ask any developer.



WHY THIS MATTERS

An hourly estimate is a guess *wearing a suit.*

Most software budgets don't blow up because developers are slow. They blow up because nobody wrote down, clearly, what "done" means. The fix costs nothing and takes an afternoon: a one-page brief.

47%

of unsuccessful projects missed their goals mainly because of poor requirements management.

PMI PULSE OF THE PROFESSION [1]

45%

average budget overrun on large IT projects, which also delivered 56% less value than predicted.

MCKINSEY & OXFORD, 5,400 PROJECTS [2]

1 page

is enough. A clear page beats a vague 40-page document, because people actually read it.

OUR RULE OF THUMB

Small projects aren't immune; they just fail more quietly. The app arrives, it's "almost" right, and every fix becomes another invoice. A good brief changes the conversation: instead of paying for hours, you can ask for a **fixed price for a defined result**, and you have something concrete to test the result against.

You don't need technical words. You need seven clear answers.

Developers can translate "the driver taps Delivered and the customer gets a text" into code. What they can't do is guess your business rules, your deadlines or what success looks like. That's what the brief is for.

A brief that gets you a guess

"We need an app to manage our catering orders. Something modern and user-friendly, like Uber but for catering, with AI. ASAP."

A brief that gets you a price

"We lose about 1 in 10 catering enquiries because they sit in three inboxes. We need one place where enquiries arrive, get a quote within 24 hours, and turn into confirmed orders the kitchen can see. 4 office staff, ~60 orders a month."

What to write, *box by box.*

01 **The problem, in one sentence, with a number.**
Not the solution: the pain. Numbers make it real and help everyone judge what the fix is worth.

"We need a CRM."	"Follow-ups slip: about 30 leads a month never get a second call."

02 **Who uses it, and how many.**
List the kinds of people (roles), how many of each, and where they'll be: at a desk, on a phone in a truck, at home on a tablet. "3 office staff on laptops, 12 drivers on Android phones, about 200 customers who log in once a month."

03 **The one job it must do on day one.**
If the app did only one thing well, what would it be? That's your **Must**. Everything else goes on a **Later** list. This single habit does more to control cost than anything else in this guide.

04 **What exists today.**
The tools, spreadsheets, paper forms and inboxes involved now; the data you'll bring with you (roughly how many rows); and anything it must connect to (QuickBooks, Stripe, Google Workspace, your website). Attach a **sample with fake names** and screenshots of the current mess. Messy is fine; it's honest.

Tip: record a 5-minute screen video

Open the spreadsheet or tool you use today and talk through a normal day: "This comes in by email, then I copy it here, then I colour it yellow until the client confirms..." It's the fastest way to share hidden rules, and engineers love it. Your phone's screen recorder or a free tool like Loom is enough.

Rules, results *and limits.*

05 **Rules and exceptions.**
The "if this, then that" of your business. These are where surprises hide, so write down every one you can think of: "Orders after 2 p.m. ship next day." "Refunds over $200 need a manager." "Clients in Ontario pay HST, not GST + QST." "A job can't be closed without a photo."

06 **How you'll know it works.**
Three to ten short statements you'll test before you accept and pay. These are called **acceptance criteria**, and they're the heart of a fixed price. See the box below.

07 **Constraints.**
Deadline *and why* (a trade show? end of fiscal year?), a budget range (yes, share it: it lets the developer propose the right size of solution instead of guessing), languages (French and English?), where data must live (Canada?), and whether it holds personal information (see guide 05).

Acceptance criteria, made simple

Use one pattern: **When** [someone] **does** [something], **then** [this happens]. If you can't test it, rewrite it.

UNTESTABLE	TESTABLE
"Fast"	A page opens in under 2 seconds on a phone with a normal mobile connection.
"User-friendly"	Two of our drivers log their first delivery without help, on their own phones.
"Secure"	A customer can only ever see their own orders. Staff need a password and a second step to sign in.
"Good reporting"	When the manager clicks Monthly report, then a PDF with orders, revenue and tax per month downloads.
"Notifications"	When an order is marked Delivered, then the customer gets an email within 1 minute, in their language.

SCOPE TRAPS

Six phrases that *quietly double a quote.*

Each of these sounds small in a meeting and turns into weeks of work. You may still want them. Just say exactly what you mean.

IF YOU WRITE…	…A DEVELOPER HEARS	WRITE THIS INSTEAD
"Like Uber, but for..."	Live maps, matching, payments, ratings, two apps, millions of dollars.	Name the **one** feature you liked: "Customers see the driver is on the way."
"Integrate with everything"	Unknown systems, unknown access, unknown data quality.	List each system and the direction: "Send paid invoices to QuickBooks, nightly."
"Real-time"	Always-on connections, extra infrastructure.	How fresh is fresh enough? "Within 5 minutes" is often far cheaper than "instantly".
"Admins can change anything"	A settings screen for every rule: a second app.	List the 3 to 5 things that actually change: prices, staff, opening hours.
"AI-powered"	Unclear: chat? extraction? predictions? Plus review and privacy work.	Say the job: "Read supplier PDFs and pre-fill the order, for a human to check."
"Mobile app"	Native iOS and Android, app-store reviews, two code bases.	"Works well on phones." An installable web app often does the job for a fraction.

Sort every wish into three lists

MUST

Without it, version one is pointless. Keep this list painfully short. Three to seven items.

LATER

Valuable, but it can wait until real people have used version one. You'll be surprised how many items move to Never.

NEVER

Writing these down is a gift: it stops them creeping back in during week three.

TEMPLATE · FILL IT IN

My one-page app brief

01 The problem, with a number

What hurts today, and how often or how much?

02 Who uses it, how many, on what

Roles · number of people · desk, phone, tablet

03 Must (day one) · Later · Never

Three to seven Musts

04 What exists today

Tools, files, data volume, systems to connect

05 Rules and exceptions

"If... then..." · approvals · taxes · cut-off times

06 Done means (acceptance criteria)

When [someone] does [something], then [result]

07 Constraints

Deadline + why · budget range · languages · hosting · personal data?

+ Attachments

☐ sample data (fake names) ☐ screenshots ☐ 5-min video

WORKED EXAMPLE

A real-looking brief, *start to finish.*

Plateau Catering Co. is fictional. The shape is what matters: notice how short it is.

1 · Problem. Catering enquiries arrive by email, phone and our website form, and sit in three places. We lose about 1 in 10 (roughly 6 a month at ~$900 each), and quotes take 2 to 3 days.

2 · Users. 4 office staff (laptops), 2 kitchen leads (tablet on the wall), ~60 client companies a month (phones and laptops, French and English).

3 · Must: one inbox for all enquiries; quote builder from our menu with taxes; client accepts the quote online; confirmed orders appear on the kitchen screen by date. **Later:** deposits by card; repeat-order button. **Never:** our own delivery tracking (we use a courier).

4 · Today. Gmail, a Google Sheet of orders (2 years, ~1,400 rows, sample attached with fake names), menu in a Word file, QuickBooks Online for invoices.

5 · Rules. Orders need 48 h notice, 5 days for 100+ guests. Quotes expire after 7 days. Delivery fee by postal-code zone (list attached). Changes after confirmation need a manager's OK. GST + QST on everything.

6 · Done means.

- When an enquiry arrives by any channel, then it's in the shared inbox within 5 minutes, assigned to nobody until someone takes it.
- When staff build a quote, then taxes and the delivery fee are added automatically and the client gets a link in their language.
- When the client accepts, then the order appears on the kitchen screen for its date, and an invoice draft is created in QuickBooks.
- A client can only see their own quotes and orders.

7 · Constraints. Live before the December party season (Nov 25). Budget range $8k to $15k. French and English. Data hosted in Canada if possible. Holds client names, emails and phone numbers.

Why this works: an engineer can price every line of it, spot the risky part (the QuickBooks link) in one read, and ask three good questions instead of thirty.

BEFORE YOU SIGN ANYTHING

12 questions to ask *any developer.*

ASK	THE ANSWER YOU WANT
1. Is the price fixed for each piece of work, or hourly?	Fixed per defined piece, quoted before work starts. Hourly is fine for exploration, but with a cap.
2. What exactly is included, and what counts as a change?	A written scope with acceptance criteria. Changes are quoted separately before they're done.
3. Who owns the code, the data, the domain and the accounts?	You do, from day one, in accounts in your company's name.
4. Will I test it before it goes live?	Yes, on a separate staging version, with your own test cases.
5. What happens if it doesn't pass my acceptance criteria?	They fix it at no extra cost. You pay when it passes.
6. Do you use AI, and who checks its work?	Yes is fine. A named engineer reviews every change and runs tests (see guide 03).
7. Where will my data be stored? Can it stay in Canada?	A clear answer naming the provider and region, not "in the cloud".
8. How will I know how it's going?	Written progress updates on a schedule, and something you can click early.
9. What will it cost per month to run?	Hosting, licences, email and any paid services listed, with numbers.
10. What happens after launch?	A warranty period for bugs, then an optional care plan with response times.
11. Can I see something similar you built that's live?	A link you can click today, not just screenshots.
12. If we stop working together, how do I get everything?	Code, documentation, data export and account handover, in writing.

Red flags

No written scope · "We'll figure it out as we go" with open hourly billing · the developer owns the hosting account or the code · no testing step before launch · can't show live work · pressure to sign today.

CHECKLIST · BEFORE YOU SEND IT

Send it *with confidence.*

- [ ] The problem has a **number** in it.
- [ ] The **Must** list has seven items or fewer.
- [ ] Every acceptance criterion could be **tested by someone else** in your team.
- [ ] You wrote down at least five **rules or exceptions**.
- [ ] You shared a **budget range** and the **reason** behind the deadline.
- [ ] Attachments use **fake names**, never real customer data.
- [ ] You marked whether the app will hold **personal information**.
- [ ] You've picked who on your side will **test and accept** the work.

This template is exactly what we ask for

At Addanapp, the brief is step one. An engineer turns it into acceptance criteria, flags the risks and sends a fixed price. Nothing starts until you approve, and you're only invoiced after you've tested and accepted the result.

SOURCES

1. Project Management Institute, "Requirements Management: A Core Competency for Project and Program Success", Pulse of the Profession in-depth report (2014), survey of more than 2,000 practitioners: 47% of unsuccessful projects failed to meet goals due to poor requirements management.
2. Michael Bloch, Sven Blumberg and Jürgen Laartz, "Delivering large-scale IT projects on time, on budget, and on value", McKinsey & Company with the University of Oxford, October 2012. Over 5,400 IT projects; "large" means an initial budget above US$15 million.

Addanapp

FROM THE TEAM AT ADDANAPP.COM

Know what you need? *We'll tell you what it costs.*

Addanapp is a Montréal software studio. We build business apps, portals, back-offices and integrations at AI speed, and a senior engineer signs off every change before it reaches you.

A fixed price first
Every request is quoted before work starts. Nothing starts until you approve.

No acceptance, no invoice
You test it on a staging version. If it doesn't meet the criteria, we fix it at no extra cost.

Human-validated
AI drafts, engineers decide. Line-by-line review, tests and security checks on every change.

You own everything
Code, data and accounts are yours from day one. Built with Law 25 and PIPEDA in mind.

Send a short brief (the template in guide 02 is perfect) and an engineer, not a salesperson, will reply with questions or a fixed quote.

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